

There is a moment that recurs across almost every transformation I have been part of, in almost every setting imaginable. A strategy has been approved. The logic is sound. The people in the room are capable, experienced and, by every measure that matters, aligned. And yet, within weeks, they begin building different futures.

I have watched this happen on the boundary of the Arabian Gulf, where a rugby club's committee needed to redefine the game it was playing before it could redefine its strategy. I have watched it happen in Botswana, where intelligent executives left the same strategy workshops and returned to their desks to enact three or four subtly different organisations. I have watched it happen inside one of the Gulf's oldest family conglomerates, where a beautifully engineered governance structure could not explain why some executives became architects of transformation and others quietly waited it out. And I have watched it happen in diversity, equity and inclusion programmes, where identical policies, applied with identical rigour, produced leaders who championed inclusion, leaders who complied without conviction, and leaders who disengaged altogether.

For years I treated these as unrelated puzzles, each demanding its own explanation. It was only in bringing them together — across industries, geographies and governance systems — that a single, underlying pattern became visible. This piece draws that pattern together. It is, in effect, the synthesis beneath everything else I have written under the banner of A View on Change: the Worldview LOA

Framework, and the case it makes for a different starting point in how we understand strategic transformation.

The Question Beneath the Question

Every one of these engagements began with a conventional diagnostic question. In Botswana, it was: what should our strategy be? In the Gulf conglomerate, it was: how should our governance be structured? In the rugby club, it was: what should our strategic priorities be for the coming seasons? In the diversity and inclusion work, it was: why don't our policies produce consistent behaviour?

Each of these questions assumes that the answer lies in getting the content right — the right strategic direction, the right organisational architecture, the right governance framework, the right policy. And in each case, once the content was right, a second and more stubborn question emerged, one that no amount of strategic sophistication seemed able to resolve.

Why do capable people, exposed to the same information, working under the same structures and accountable to the same expectations, arrive at fundamentally different levels of commitment?

The answer, I have come to believe, is that organisations do not simply create strategies, structures and policies that people execute. They create institutional environments that people continually interpret. And it is that act of interpretation — occurring in the invisible space between the decision and the behaviour — that ultimately determines whether transformation becomes a lived reality or a document on a shelf.

I have come to call this space the white space between reporting lines. Reporting lines establish authority. Governance allocates accountability. Decision rights clarify who may decide. Performance systems specify what should be achieved. None of these mechanisms determines how an individual executive interprets the meaning of those expectations before deciding how they will act. That interpretive work belongs to the executive alone, and it is shaped by forces no organisational chart can capture.

Three Evaluations, Not One Decision

The Worldview LOA Framework — Legitimacy, Obligation, Agency — names the three evaluations that consistently appeared beneath the surface of every engagement, regardless of sector, geography or governance tradition.

Legitimacy asks whether the proposed direction is right, appropriate and defensible — not merely approved through correct process, but consistent with the organisation's purpose and identity. A board can unanimously ratify a strategy, and executives may still, privately, question whether it represents the

right future. Where legitimacy remains unresolved, compliance may follow, but genuine commitment will not.

Obligation asks what leaders believe they are genuinely responsible for, and to whom. This is not the obligation written into a job description. It is a felt sense of stewardship — toward shareholders in one context, toward family and legacy in another, toward community, colleagues or the institution itself in others. Two executives can carry identical formal responsibilities while experiencing entirely different senses of ownership over the outcome.

Agency asks whether leaders believe they possess sufficient authority, influence and psychological safety to make a meaningful difference. Agency is not confidence, and it is not competence. It is the lived experience of power within a particular organisation — whether difficult truths can be spoken, whether delegated authority will actually be respected, whether a leader's actions are likely to matter.

What makes these three evaluations powerful is not that they operate independently, but that they interact. Legitimacy strengthens obligation. Obligation reinforces the willingness to exercise agency. A collapse in perceived agency can erode commitment even where legitimacy and obligation remain intact. Two executives can therefore endorse exactly the same strategic framework while holding entirely different assumptions about its legitimacy, their obligation to champion it, and their capacity to influence its success — and those differences inevitably surface during implementation, however invisible they were during planning.

Crucially, the framework does not sort executives into fixed types. It is not a personality model. It describes a dynamic, evolving process of evaluation that shifts with organisational experience and changing governance conditions, which is precisely why the same leader can respond differently to different initiatives, and why identical initiatives can produce different responses across a leadership team.

Three Moments, Not One Announcement

If Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency describe what leaders evaluate, a second layer of the framework — the three moments of change — describes how those evaluations unfold over time as a change initiative moves from announcement to embedded practice.

The first moment is internalisation. As executives encounter a new change strategy, they do not simply decide whether to support it; they evaluate whether it aligns with what they believe is legitimate, appropriate and worthwhile. This produces three distinct patterns. Some suppress the change, delaying action or complying only symbolically. Others exploit it, treating the initiative as an opportunity to reinforce existing interests or authority. Others engage in genuine exchange, treating the strategy as a

shared opportunity for learning and improvement. On the surface these three responses can look similar — attendance at the same meetings, sign-off on the same plans — but they represent fundamentally different interpretations of the same intervention.

The second moment is worldview activation. Here, the deeper evaluative structure comes into play: is the change morally legitimate, do I feel obligated to support it, do I believe I have the agency to influence its outcome? When these evaluations align, leaders experience commitment, confidence and purpose. When they conflict with deeply held beliefs or identities, resistance, uncertainty and disengagement follow — not because people have rejected the facts of the strategy, but because they have constructed a different meaning from it.

The third moment is enactment through position-practices — the everyday leadership behaviours through which evaluations become visible: how resources are allocated, which conversations are reshaped, which decision-making forums are redesigned, which norms are reinforced or allowed to erode. Transformation succeeds when new meanings become visible through new patterns of leadership behaviour, and stalls when leaders quietly continue operating according to the logic of the organisation that used to exist.

This three-moment structure sits alongside, rather than in competition with, two of the field's most enduring models. Chin and Benne's change strategies — empirical-rational, normative-re-educative and power-coercive — explain how leaders attempt to influence change. Lewin's unfreeze–change–refreeze sequence explains where an organisation sits within the change journey. Neither, on its own, explains why leaders exposed to identical strategies moving through identical stages so often respond so differently. The three moments supply that missing explanation, because they attend to what is happening inside people rather than only to what is happening to the organisation. Acceleration does not come from greater urgency, tighter timelines or heavier governance. It comes from leaders internalising change through genuine exchange rather than suppression, from worldviews activating through legitimacy, obligation and agency rather than fear or compliance, and from those evaluations being consistently reinforced through everyday leadership practice. Organisations move faster when people change sooner — and people change sooner when their evaluations, not merely their instructions, are addressed.

The Executive Sextant: Taking a Fix on Judgement

Long before I had language for any of this, I trained as a navigator. Before satellite positioning, a navigator confirmed a vessel's position not from a single reading but by taking three independent bearings and triangulating where they intersected — a fix. No navigator sets a course from a single bearing, however confident it feels. A fix requires three lines crossing.

I have come to think of Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency as exactly this kind of triangulation, and I describe the discipline of holding them together as Evaluative Reflexivity — the practice of bringing three evaluative bearings into view at once, examining where they align or pull apart, and only then determining a genuine evaluative position before acting.

Legitimacy is the bearing that establishes true north: what is right, credible and worthy of trust, independent of who approved it. Obligation is the bearing that commits a leader to the voyage: what responsibility actually demands of them, not merely what a job description states. Agency is the bearing that sets the course: what a leader can realistically do — their genuine capacity to influence events and mobilise others, given the structural realities in which they operate.

Any one bearing, taken alone, is unreliable. An executive convinced only of legitimacy, without obligation or agency, produces intellectual assent without commitment. An executive who feels obligation without believing the direction legitimate produces anxious compliance. An executive with agency but no sense of obligation or legitimacy produces capable action pointed in the wrong direction. Only where the three bearings intersect does an executive establish a reliable fix — a genuine, examined evaluative position from which a course of action can be set with integrity.

> *A navigator never sets a course before taking a fix. Executive judgement should be no different.* — *Dr. George Kesselaar*

This is where the practical instrument comes in — the Executive Sextant Process, a six-stage sequence showing how a fix, once taken, is actually applied moment to moment. It begins with Observation: attending to what is genuinely present in a situation, before interpretation. It moves to Appraisal, the first-pass evaluation an executive's existing schema makes automatically, usually below conscious awareness. The critical stage is the Angle of Appraisal — examining the precise vantage point from which a situation is being read, because a small shift in that angle changes the interpretation and the response dramatically, in exactly the way a small error in a bearing produces a large error in position over distance. From there, Judgement is the considered verdict that integrates observation, appraisal and angle-awareness into a coherent assessment. Engagement is the quality and orientation a leader brings into the situation as a result. And Behaviour — the visible actions, decisions and communications — is simply where all of this becomes observable to everyone else.

Every case discussed in this piece can be read through this instrument. The rugby club committee members who diverged over the meaning of the same renewed vision had, in effect, taken their fix from different angles of appraisal. The Gulf conglomerate executives who quietly continued operating by the old logic had not yet re-established legitimacy as a bearing; their obligation and agency, however strong, had nowhere stable to anchor. Structural interventions can improve the instrument panel. They cannot, by themselves, take the fix.

Four Settings, One Pattern

A rugby club on the edge of institutional change. In the Arabian Gulf, a leading rugby organisation asked for a conventional strategic framework: a vision, a set of priorities, an implementation plan. The deeper work, however, began by recognising that the game itself was changing around the club — a new national governing body, a commercially transforming stadium precinct, strengthening rivals, and governments investing seriously in sport for the first time. The strategy that emerged was sound, and it remains sound in hindsight. What was missing, only visible years later, was any mechanism for establishing whether the committee shared a common interpretation of that future. Some read the renewed vision as an ambitious growth agenda; others read it as consolidation. Both endorsed the strategy. Both began implementing different futures. Strategic alignment, it turns out, is an interpretive achievement as much as an organisational one.

A state enterprise and the limits of organisation design. The puzzle first became visible in Botswana, at the Botswana Meat Commission, where a sound competitive strategy met executives who, despite sharing identical information, appeared to be inhabiting different organisations. A later engagement, redesigning governance, reporting lines and incentive systems around an existing strategy, tested the conventional wisdom that structure follows strategy — and confirmed it, up to a point. Even where organisational alignment improved substantially, executive commitment remained uneven: some leaders flourished, others complied without conviction, others quietly continued operating by the old logic. Nothing in the organisational chart explained the difference, because the chart was never where the difference lived.

A family conglomerate and the white space between reporting lines. In one of the Gulf's oldest family-owned business groups, a meticulously designed governance transformation — new boards, a new Transformation Group CEO, new delegations of authority — still left the deepest risks unaddressed, because family boards are not simply governance structures; they are interpretive institutions where owners, family members, executives, independent directors and the next generation each carry different histories and loyalties into the same room. The recommendations that followed — executive coaching, clearer role descriptions, behavioural scorecards — looked, at the time, like conventional governance interventions. Viewed through Worldview LOA, they were something more precise: coaching strengthened agency, role clarity strengthened legitimacy, and behavioural scorecards strengthened relational obligation. Resistance in that setting did not stem from a preference for the status quo; it stemmed from the fact that the existing way of understanding the organisation still felt legitimate, relationally appropriate and personally safe. Behaviour changes only after interpretation changes.

A diversity and inclusion strategy and the question of power. Perhaps the clearest demonstration of the framework's reach lies outside strategic transformation altogether, in diversity, equity and inclusion.

Organisations with the same policy, the same governance structure and the same training investment routinely produce leaders who champion inclusion, leaders who comply while changing nothing in practice, and leaders who quietly disengage. Because agency in this context is profoundly shaped by power asymmetry, the underlying research adds a further concept worth carrying into any transformation context: reflexive equity, the disciplined practice of examining one's own assumptions, positionality and the structures of power influencing one's decisions. Leaders who do this strengthen the alignment between legitimacy and obligation, and make their commitment to inclusion — or to any change — considerably more resilient over time.

The Voyage of Executive Judgement

If the Sextant explains how a single judgement is formed, it does not, on its own, explain how a leader's entire orientation to change develops over the course of a transformation — sometimes over years rather than moments. For that, I map a longer passage: the Voyage of Executive Judgement, an eight-stage developmental journey that is rarely linear, and is better understood as a passage leaders move through, loop back within, and sometimes dwell in far longer than any transformation timeline anticipates.

The voyage begins with Encounter — first contact with the imperative for change, the moment an executive recognises that their current mode of leading is no longer sufficient. It is met, almost always, by Resistance: not simple obstruction, but the natural protective response of an existing worldview defending itself, and — this matters — a response that carries real intelligence about what the existing interpretation was protecting. This is the same point made earlier in relation to the Gulf family business: resistance persists not because people prefer the status quo, but because their existing interpretation still feels legitimate, relationally appropriate and personally safe. The Voyage names this as a stage rather than a failure, which changes how a leader responds to it.

Genuine transformation requires passing through Inquiry — the point where an executive begins to hold their own worldview as an object of study rather than as the invisible lens through which everything else is seen — and, almost inevitably, Disorientation, the productive unsettling in which old certainties dissolve before new frameworks have solidified. This is uncomfortable, and it is necessary; a navigator who has left a known coastline behind but has not yet sighted the next one is disoriented in exactly this sense, and it is not a sign that the voyage has gone wrong.

From there, Reorientation marks the emergence of a revised worldview — new, more expansive frameworks for understanding self, others and organisational dynamics. Integration is the harder, slower work of weaving that revised worldview into daily leadership practice across multiple domains, rather than treating it as an insight reserved for offsites and workshops. Embodiment is the point at which the

new orientation becomes a leader's natural way of being, expressed fluently rather than effortfully. And the final destination, Transmission, is where the transformed executive becomes a generative force in their own right — capable of creating the conditions in which others can undergo their own voyage, rather than simply issuing them instructions to change.

Read against the case material above, the value of the Voyage is that it locates each engagement along a passage rather than treating it as a single verdict on whether change worked. The Botswana executives who continued deciding according to yesterday's assumptions had not stalled through incompetence; many were still somewhere between Encounter and Inquiry, never having been invited to hold their own worldview up for examination. The rugby club's committee had reached Reorientation on paper — a revised vision, genuinely agreed — without yet reaching Integration, the point at which that revised vision would have been woven into how directors actually behaved in the room. Naming the stage a leadership team is actually in, rather than the stage a transformation plan assumes they should already have reached, is frequently the single most useful diagnostic a board can perform.

Beyond a Single Governance Tradition

A further implication runs through comparative work across a multinational African financial institution and a Gulf family conglomerate, and it deserves to stand on its own. Much of strategic leadership theory has been built within Anglo-American governance assumptions, and quietly generalised as though those assumptions were universal. They are not. Executives operating within African developmental states, Gulf family enterprises, and other institutionally distinctive settings are not deviating from a Western norm; they are reasoning through different, and equally coherent, evaluative grammars — different assumptions about what legitimate authority looks like, different traditions of stewardship, different histories of institutional trust.

This matters practically, not only theoretically. Multinational organisations that invest heavily in standardising leadership competencies and transformation methodologies across regions often assume that consistency is best achieved by transferring one region's best practice to another. The evidence suggests the opposite: a common strategic ambition can be pursued across very different institutional worlds, but only if leaders are permitted to reason about legitimacy, obligation and agency within their own governance realities, rather than being asked to adopt someone else's. The goal is not uniformity of interpretation. It is coherence of purpose — executives in different institutional worlds legitimately reasoning in different ways while still contributing to the same transformation.

What This Means in Practice

Drawn together, these engagements point toward a small number of practical shifts that any board or executive team can make, regardless of sector or geography.

Begin with executive judgement before strategic judgement. Before a committee or leadership team develops strategic priorities, it is worth understanding how its members are already interpreting the future they are about to build — not through a survey, but through direct conversation about legitimacy, obligation and agency. The resulting strategy may look similar. The conversations producing it, and the durability of the commitment behind it, will be entirely different.

Treat resistance as information, not obstruction. Resistance rarely means people prefer the status quo for its own sake. More often it means the existing interpretation of the organisation still feels legitimate, relationally appropriate and personally safe, and the proposed change has not yet displaced it. Strengthening governance or compressing timelines will not resolve this; only addressing the underlying evaluation will.

Recognise that structural alignment and behavioural alignment are not the same achievement. Strategy, structure, governance, incentives and talent remain indispensable — poor design still breaks strategies, and none of this argues for abandoning that discipline. But structural coherence guarantees only that the conditions for coordinated action exist. It does not guarantee that leaders have arrived at a shared interpretation of what those conditions mean, which is a separate, interpretive achievement that has to be actively cultivated.

Ask different questions of your leadership team. Rather than asking whether people support an initiative, ask whether they believe it is legitimate, whether they experience it as a genuine responsibility rather than a compliance requirement, and whether they believe they have the authority and practical capacity to influence its outcome. The answers reveal more about an organisation's readiness for transformation than any organisational chart.

Attend to power, not only to policy. Wherever leaders are asked to act on behalf of a change — inclusion, transformation, governance renewal — their sense of agency is shaped by real asymmetries of authority and resource. Reflexive equity, the habit of examining one's own assumptions and position within those structures, strengthens the alignment between legitimacy and obligation and makes commitment more durable.

A Different Starting Point

None of this diminishes the disciplines that have long anchored strategic practice. Strategy still defines the destination. Organisation design still creates the conditions necessary for execution. Governance still establishes accountability. These remain indispensable, and getting them wrong remains one of the most common reasons transformations fail.

But none of them, on their own, determines how the people responsible for bringing a strategy to life will interpret it. That interpretive work belongs to executives themselves, and it is shaped by evaluations of legitimacy, obligation and agency that operate beneath the surface of every plan, every policy and every governance structure — usually invisible during planning, and usually decisive during implementation.

The organisations that consistently outperform their peers are rarely the ones that produce the most sophisticated strategic plans. They are the ones whose leaders first develop a shared understanding of the world they are trying to change. When executive judgement converges around a common view of legitimacy, responsibility and possibility, alignment becomes more than coordination. It becomes collective conviction.

That, in the end, is the single thread running through a decade of consulting across four continents and as many industries: the future of strategic leadership depends less on producing better strategies, and more on cultivating the executive worldviews through which those strategies are understood, owned, and ultimately brought to life. Take the fix first. Only then set the course.